Platform as a Product



Drive Adoption for Your Internal Tools

Mike Kotsur – SRE Day 2025 – Amsterdam

Platform as a Product

Agenda of the talk

- It’s all About Change
- The Promise of the Platform
- The Strength of Product Thinking
- Platform Inception Workshop
- Building and Driving Adoption



It’s all about Valuable Change

Change for the sake of change is just chaos

- A change is only valuable if it boosts your organization's success.
- Successful change requires more than just technology.
- Purposeful change drives innovation through harmonization.

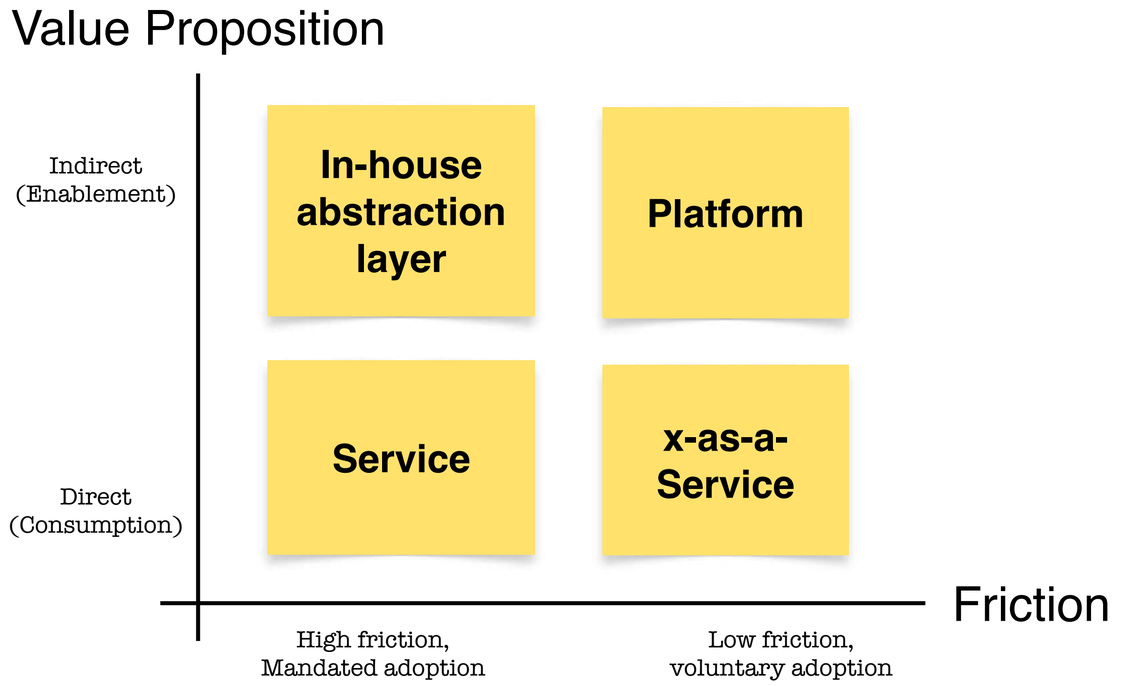


Kotter’s model of change management
(source: https://www.kotterinc.com/8-steps-process-for-leading-change/)

The promise of the Platform

A catchy buzzword or the “unfair” advantage?

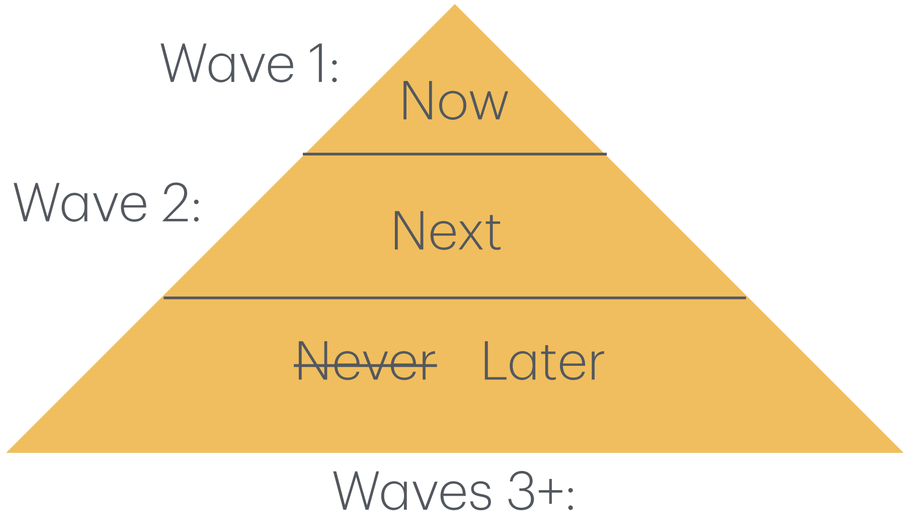
"A digital platform is a foundation of self-service APIs, tools, services, knowledge and support which are arranged as a compelling internal product.
Autonomous delivery teams can make use of the platform to deliver product features at a higher pace, with reduced co-ordination.”



Requirements elicitation

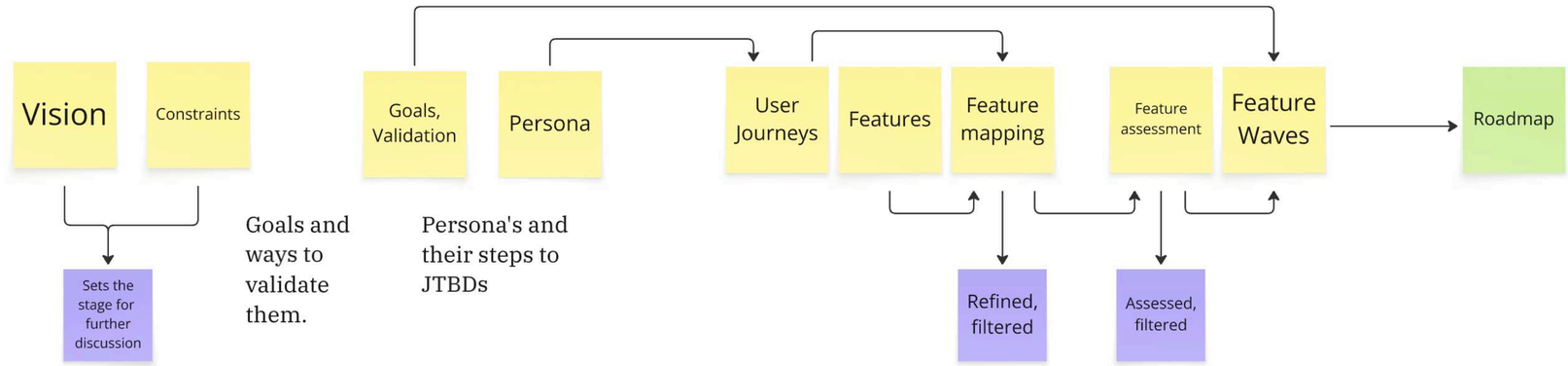
(Kind of... It's About Validation.)

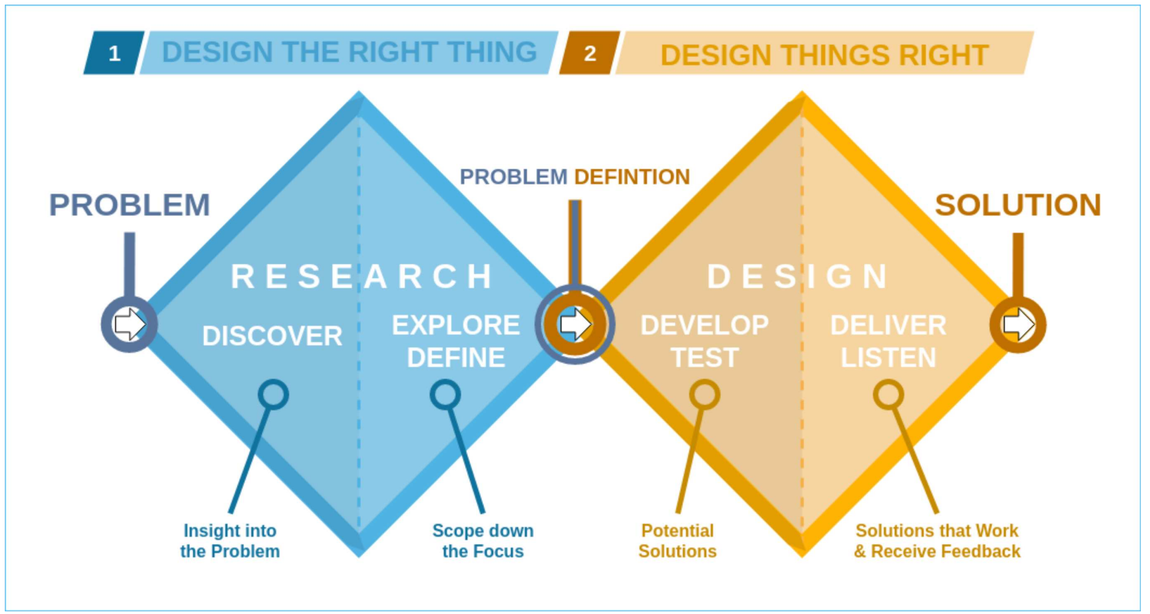
- Focus on Critical User Journeys (CUJs), not exhaustive specs.
- Ship the smallest possible increment to serve that journey.
- The question isn't "what features do they want?" but "what is the *Thinnest Viable Platform (TVP)* that makes their journey better?



How to make a roadmap?

The “road” to the platform’s roadmap





Platform Inception

Build the roadmap together

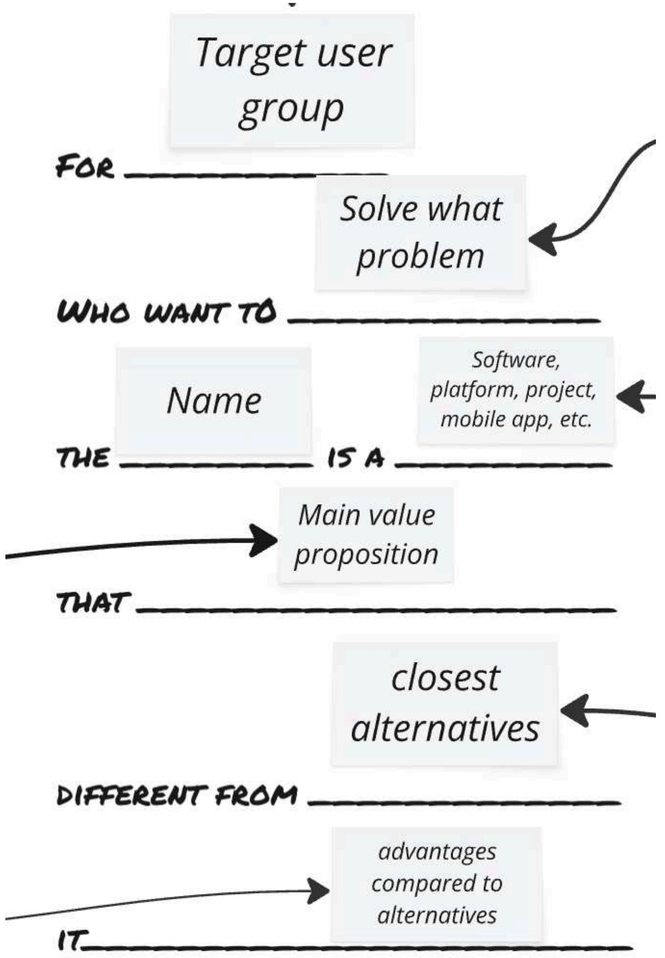
- Collaboration and Alignment;
- Converge and Diverge;
- The Art Of Gathering;
- Facilitation is crucial;
- Manage expectations;
- Create a useful mix of participants;



1. Product Vision

Insurance against falling back to the “Service” model.

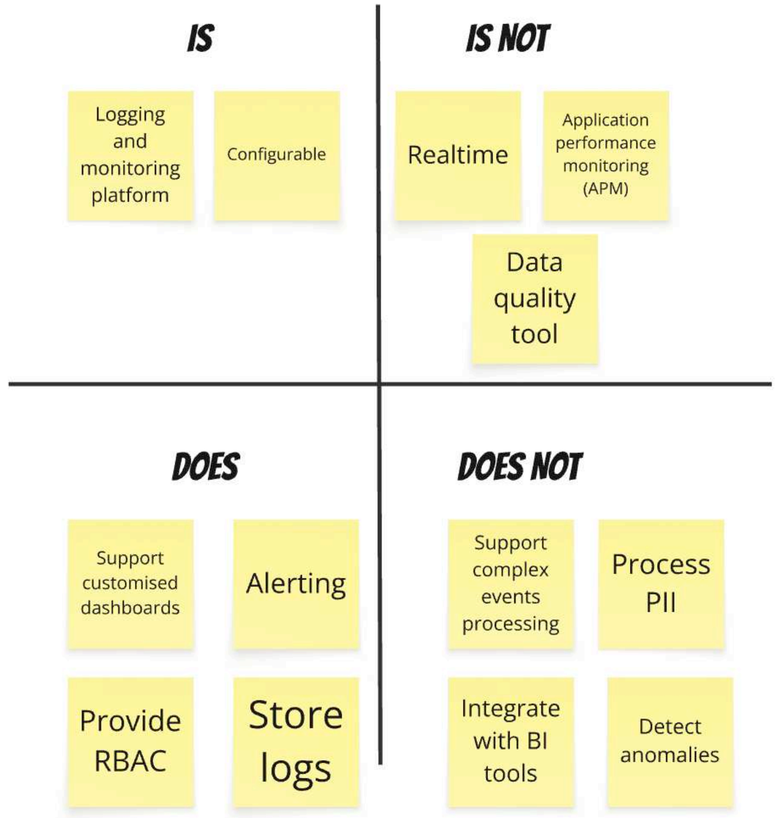
- Guides your decisions
- Make it “your own”
- Involve senior stakeholders and sponsors
- Iterate!



2. Constraints

Key [non-]ingredients for success

- IS – What is its core identity? What are its essential aspects?
- IS NOT – What may people wrongly assume it is? What is explicitly out of scope?
- DOES – What are the primary, concrete capabilities it provides?
- DOES NOT DO – What specific tasks will it never perform? Where does its responsibility end?

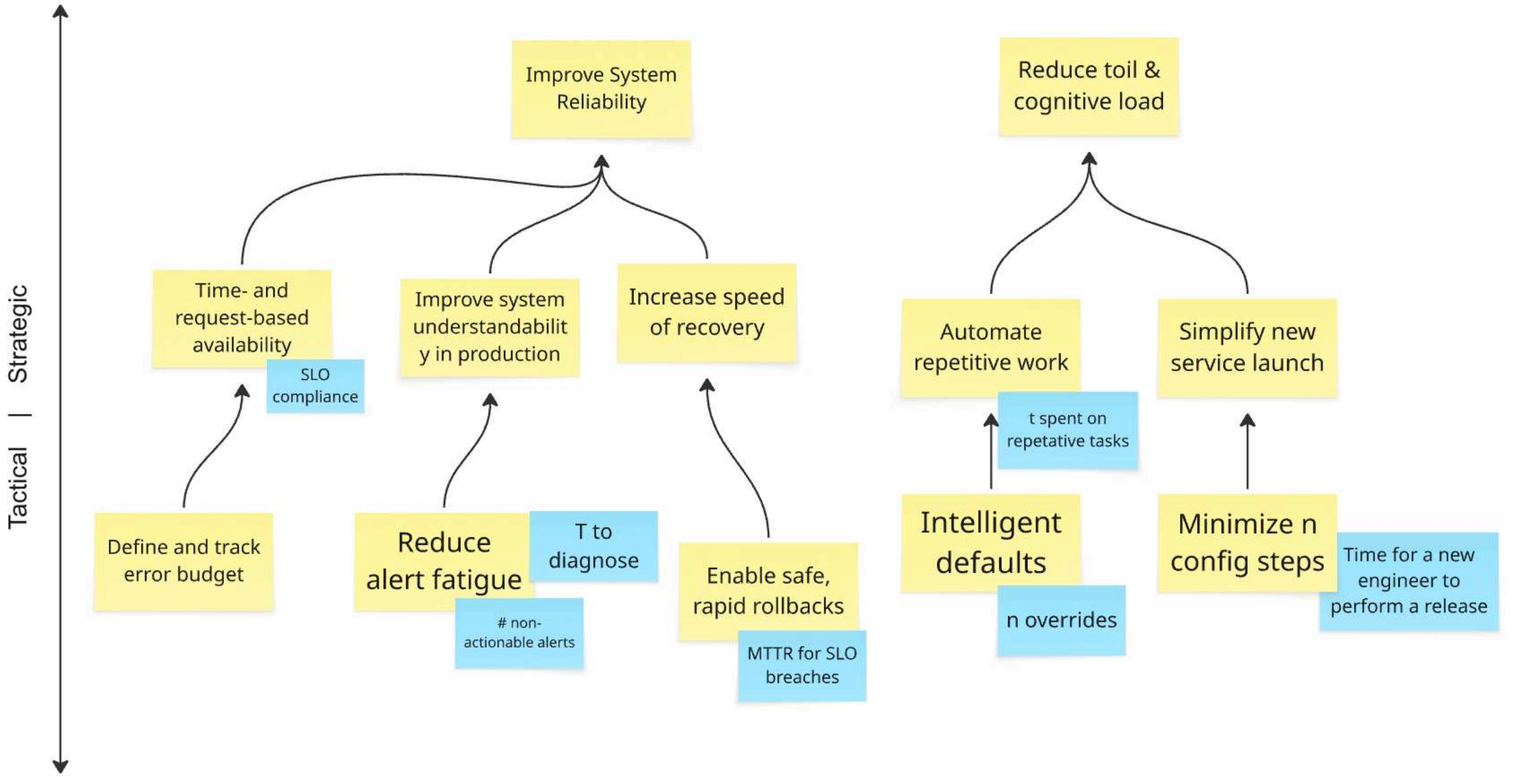


Example. Normally you will have much more of those and will have to cluster and de-duplicate them.

3. Business Goals

From Vision to Value

- Measurable outcomes that reflect true impact
- Should identify interactions between the platform and other practices in the organization
- Consider the boundaries
- Brainstorm, arrange, prioritise

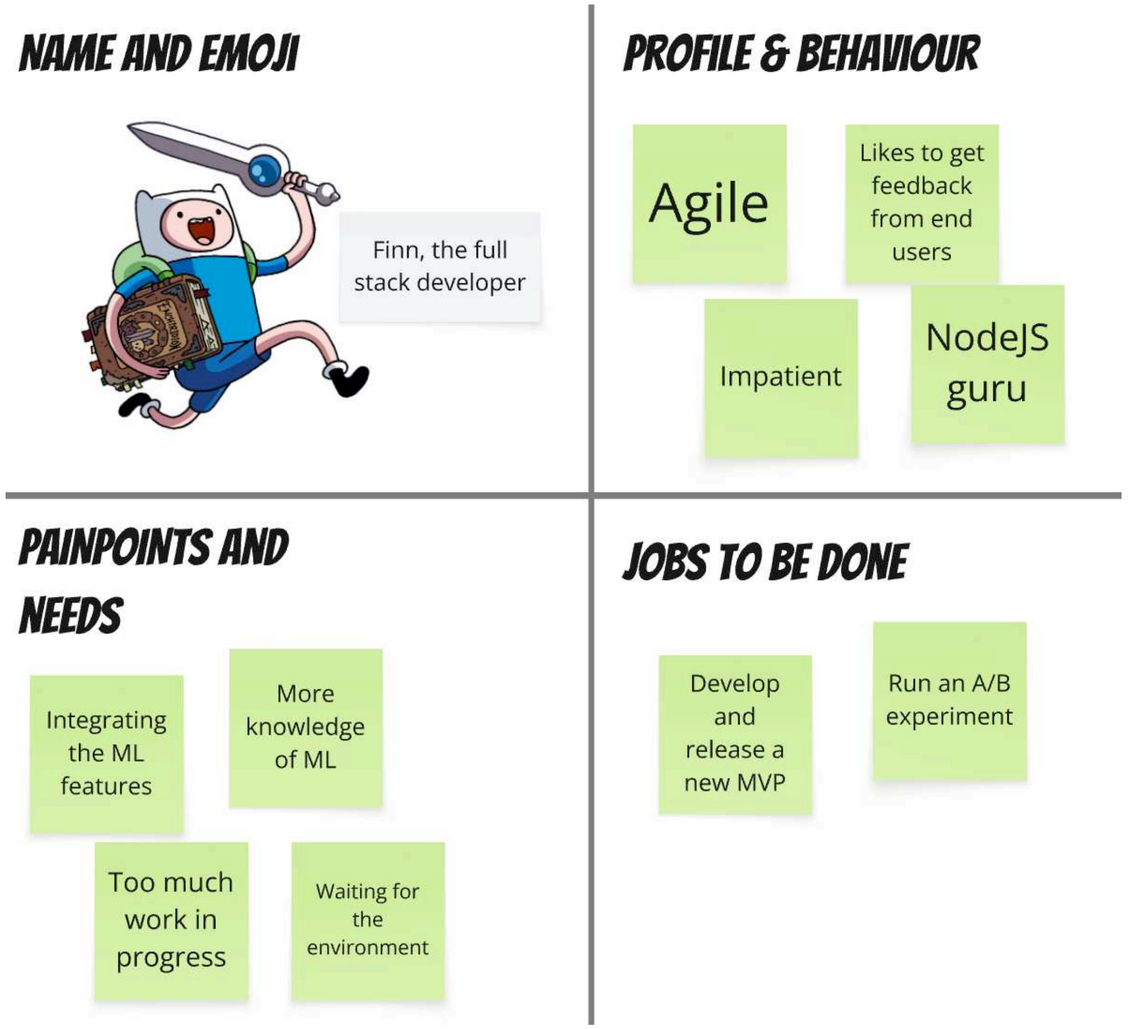


Build a tree or create groups. Get a sense of measurability of each metric.

4. Persona

Who Are We Building For?

- Empathize with your users to truly understand needs.
- You can't build for everyone at once!
- Listen, but verify. Don’t build a “faster horse”.
- Interview your potential users first!
- Smooth integration into existing workflows is important.

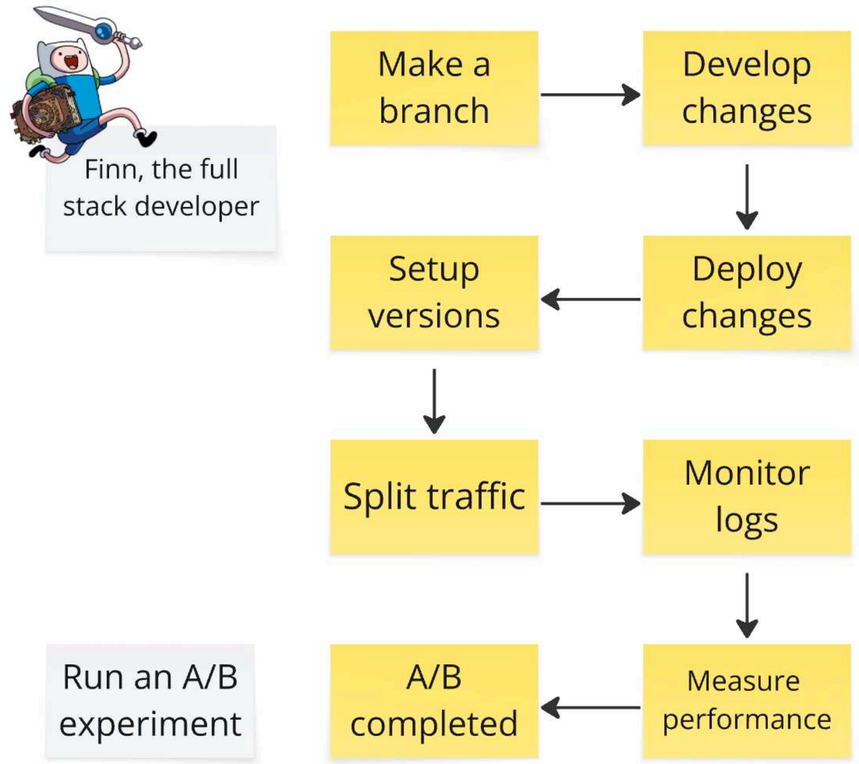


Most likely you will end up with many persona. Prioritize.

5. User Journeys

Walking in Their Shoes

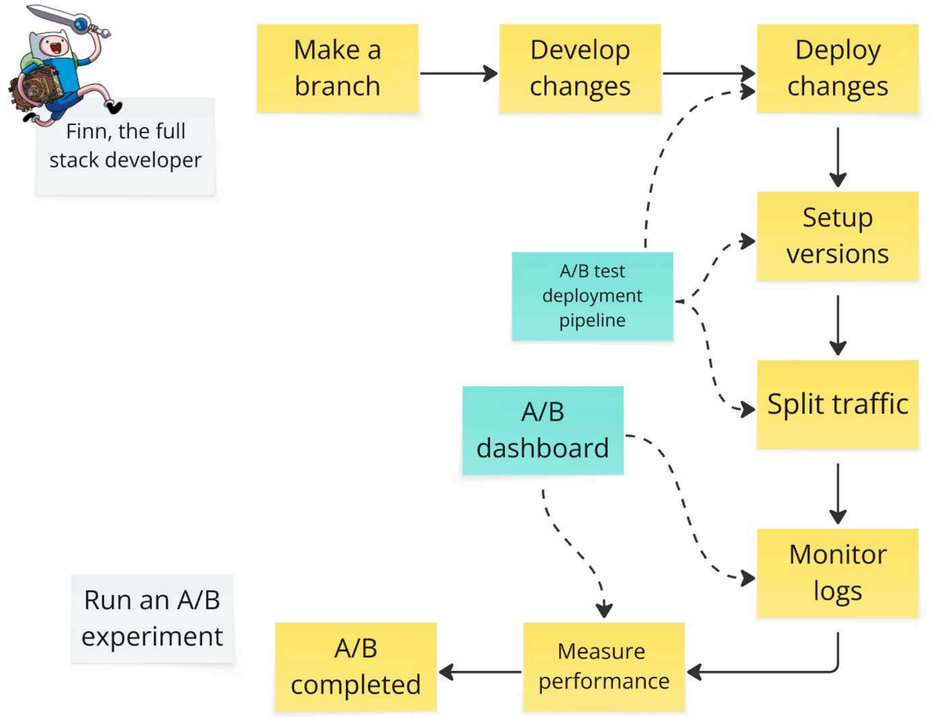
- A visualization of the steps a persona takes to complete a task, from start to finish.
- We map the current state to find the real friction points.
- Consider homegrown solutions, but find the "Invisible Cliffs”.



6. Features

Brainstorming Solutions (Finally)

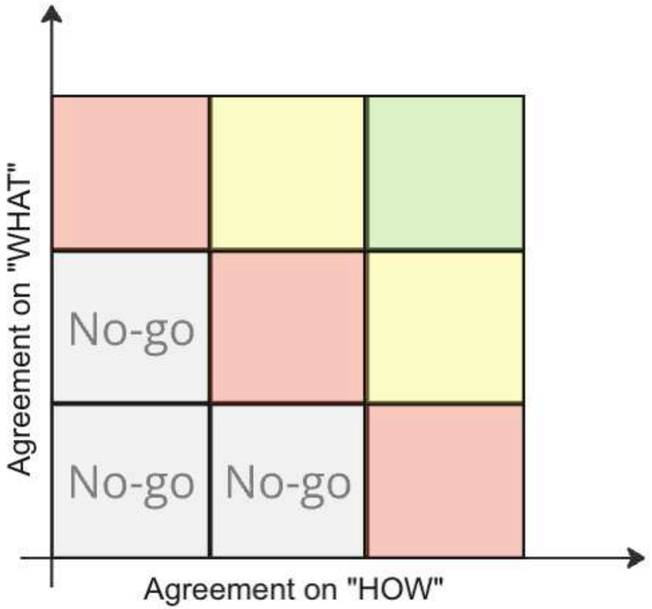
- Brainstorm features based on goals, personas and user journeys
- Harvest already proven solutions from application teams, and try joint-ventures to create and test capabilities with the teams that will use them.



7. Waves

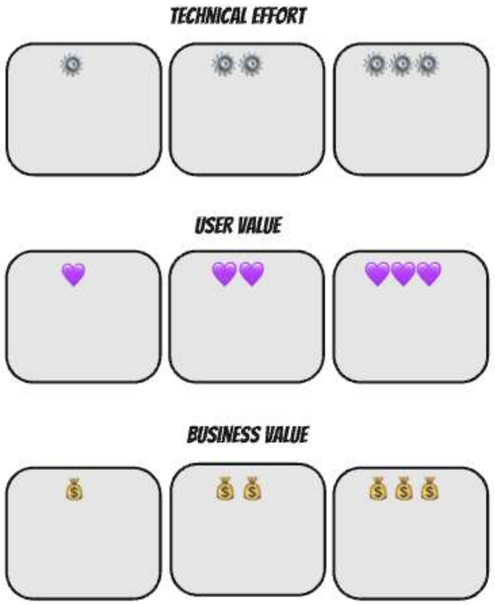
Final Convergence

Step 1: Alignment



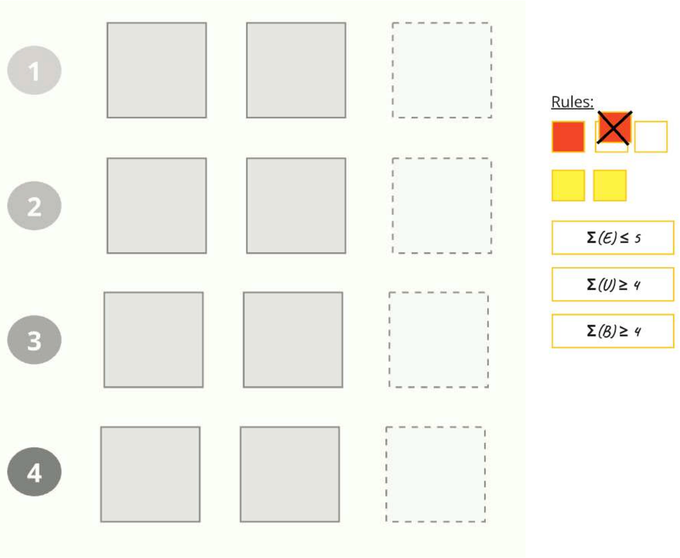
"No-go" sounds harsh, but basically this means – but in reality this means more prep work.

Step 2: Assessment



Assess each feature on for key criteria for informed prioritization.

Step 3: Sequencing



Some simple rules will ensure steady delivery of platform features.

Plan time vs Build time

Hard Work after Hard Work

- Use the outcomes of the workshop for communication
- Create space for the team to turn from Doers into Enablers
- Work in Small Batches and Establish Feedback Loops Immediately
- Your roadmap is a compass, not a fixed map
- Use Your Decision Models

